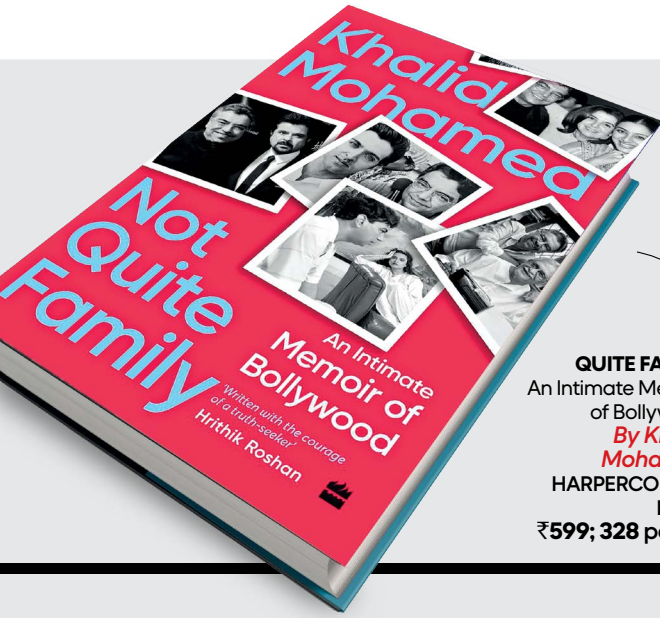


NOT QUITE FAMILY
An Intimate Memoir of Bollywood
By Khalid Mohamed
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹599; 328 pages

Having written three films—Shyam Benegal's *Mammo* (1994), *Sardari Begum* (1996) and *Zubeidaa* (2001)—that were loosely based on the women in his family, one already has glimpses into his life. He lost his mother Zubeidaa early, and it was his grandmother Fayazi 'Maaji' Begum, who brought up young Mohamed. Dedicated to Maaji, the book chronicles his lonely childhood, years of fluctuating financial stability and the joy of 'clandestine escapes to the cinema halls'.

Mohamed's first job out of college was to edit *Close-Up*, a film society monthly magazine edited by Basu Chatterjee. When the magazine shut, he went through a string of jobs from copywriting to a management internship, but nothing stuck until he landed at 'The Old Lady of Bori Bunder' aka *The Times of India* as an intern. Ready to write about murders and mayhem in the city, it was only a chance scoop interview with Linda and Paul McCartney that changed the trajectory of Mohamed's career.

For decades, Mohamed was party to intimate moments of joy and sadness in the lives of India's most famous people. It's no wonder then that his life's story features a vibrant cast including the likes of Raj Kapoor, Asha Bhosle, Rajnikanth and Dilip Kumar. His first-ever star interview taught the young reporter an important celebrity trait—little to no regard for anyone else's time, unless, of course, they are also celebrities. The lesson that Mohamed didn't learn early enough and the one that also binds the book is that no matter how often celebrities say 'you are like family', it's almost never true. *Not Quite Family* is much more than a memoir. It captures a vintage Mumbai warmth, while being a chronicle of the inner workings of a media house. ■

—Karishma Upadhyay



CINEMA ▶

In the Shadows

In *Flowers of Acacia*, filmmaker Anmol Sidhu turns his gaze on the lives of Punjab's wedding orchestra dancers, women who entertain but remain unseen

I saw these girls on stage, they seemed almost like ghosts to me, as the women in my house weren't that 'brave' to dance in front of so many men," remembers filmmaker Anmol Sidhu. That idea became *Flowers of Acacia* (*Kikkran De Phull*), Sidhu's second feature after *Jaggi* (2022), on Punjab's wedding orchestra dancers. Premiered at the New York Indian Film Festival's Centrepiece Special Night and nominated for Best Indie Film in Melbourne, its India premiere is at the Dharamshala International Film Festival.

A WEDDING DANCER'S DEATH BY BULLET MOVED SINDHU TO TRAVEL WITH AND START FILMING ORCHESTRA GROUPS

A dancer's death by bullet at a wedding stunned Sidhu, and he began travelling with orchestra groups in 2022. "Every girl I met wanted her story to be told," he says. They came from Bengal, Himachal and beyond, hence the Punjabi, Bengali and Hindi dialects in the movie. Shooting at real weddings was tough, says Sidhu; actors first danced there to acclimatise, and Bhangra novices trained for six months. The camera stays wide, avoiding close-ups; viewers sense a documentary's shadow, which he accepts. There is no redemptive ending: "Life doesn't always have a happy ending. No matter how hard I try, I can't make my stories unrealistic."

Punjabi cinema, Sidhu notes, is comedies, songs and NRI fantasy, yet *Jaggi* reached many in Punjab, proving an audience exists. "We need to make more films that aren't slapstick comedies," he adds. Another Punjab-set film awaits, with post-production nearly done. ■

—Sukant Deepak